

Canine Cognitive Dysfunction ("Doggy Dementia")

What is it?

Canine cognitive dysfunction (CCD) is an age-related brain disorder, similar to Alzheimer's disease in people. It causes gradual decline in memory, learning and awareness, with behavior changes not explained by other medical problems.

Common signs ("DISHAA")

- **Disorientation** — getting lost in familiar places, staring at walls, stuck in corners
- **Interactions change** — greets family differently, less responsive to commands
- **Sleep-wake changes** — sleeping more by day, restless or vocal at night
- **House soiling** in a previously house-trained dog
- **Activity changes** — less interest in play, exploring or food; or aimless pacing
- **Anxiety** — restlessness, pacing, vocalizing
- Trouble learning or remembering routines

Diagnosis

Based on signs and **ruling out other conditions** that look similar (pain, vision or hearing loss, hormonal, kidney or liver disease, brain tumors):

- Physical and neurological exam
- Blood and urine tests
- MRI in some cases

Treatment

CCD cannot be cured, but signs can often be improved.

Medication and supplements

- **Selegiline (Anipryl®)** — FDA-approved for CCD
- Antioxidants, omega-3 fatty acids, SAMe
- **MCT (medium-chain triglyceride)** diets or supplements — an alternative brain energy source (e.g., Purina NeuroCare)
- Medications for anxiety or night-time restlessness when needed

Enrichment

- Gentle daily exercise
- Food puzzles, interactive toys, short training sessions
- **Consistent daily routine**; avoid rearranging furniture

Supportive care

- Night lights; more frequent potty breaks
- Ramps or steps; comfortable, easy-to-reach beds

Quality of life

Ask yourself regularly: Is my dog still enjoying daily activities? Eating and resting comfortably? Having more good days than bad? We are here to help you through these decisions.

Remember — these changes come from the brain, **not disobedience**. Patience and small adjustments make a big difference.

Contact us if

Signs suddenly worsen, new behaviors appear, or your dog seems painful, distressed or stops eating or drinking.

Resources: Texas Veterinary Behavior Services (texasvetbehavior.com) · Dog Aging Project (dogagingproject.org)